fought to restore their vision for Cuba's future, but they did it from what some Cubans came to call "el exterior" – outside of the country. Castro, historian María Cristina García suggests, was able to "export dissent."[5] Or perhaps the dissenters exported themselves. "Most Cubans who traveled to the U.S. did so under the assumption that their stay would be temporary and they would soon return to their homeland … Most émigrés believed that it was just a matter of time before the United States intervened" to overthrow the revolutionary government.[6] In Cuba, this kind of support for U.S. intervention was derided as *plattismo*, after the long-discredited Platt Amendment.

In some ways, Cuba's experience with emigration in the late twentieth century was typical of Central America and the Caribbean. Most of the Caribbean islands saw 10 percent or even more of their population emigrate during this period. Puerto Rico stood out with 40 percent of its 5 million people leaving for the United States. The Dominican Republic, with approximately 10 million inhabitants, saw 1.1 million emigrate to the United States.

But in many other ways, Cuba's emigration was unique. For most people who want to immigrate to the United States, it's extremely difficult to obtain permission to do so legally. Since 1965, U.S. law has placed a limit of about 20,000 immigrant visas per year on every country. (Before 1965, there was no numerical restriction on immigrants from the Western hemisphere.)

Note that the 20,000 refers to *immigrant* visas. People who want to visit the United States temporarily can apply for other types of visas, like student or tourist visas. Immigration law also creates a special category for *refugees*. Since World War II, the United States has allowed certain people – mostly from Communist countries – to apply for refugee status. The 1962 Migration and Refugee Assistance Act and the 1966 Cuban Adjustment Act allowed virtually all Cubans who tried to come to the United States to obtain refugee status. Over a million Cubans took advantage of this opportunity by the 1990s.

Thus Cubans held a unique status under U.S. immigration law. Many people from other parts of Latin America, even those fleeing war, repression, and persecution on a much greater scale than what Cubans